

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Colossians

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The letter to the Colossians combines profound teaching about Christ with practical guidance for daily life. More than almost any other New Testament book, Colossians reminds believers that Christ must have first place in their love, devotion, and worship.

Setting

The city of Colossae was about 193 kilometers (120 miles) east of Ephesus, in the province of Asia (in modern-day Turkey).

The apostle Paul mentions Epaphras as the person who first brought the good news about Jesus to the Colossians (1:7). Epaphras probably became a Christian during Paul's three-year ministry in Ephesus. Ephesus was the main commercial area and center of government for the entire province, which included Colossae.

Luke tells us that during Paul's time in Ephesus, "everyone who lived in the province of Asia ... heard the word of the Lord" (Acts 19:10). Although Paul had not visited Colossae, he was the spiritual "father" of Epaphras and thus the spiritual "grandfather" of their church (Colossians 2:1). So he wrote with both the authority of an apostle (a messenger chosen by Jesus) and with personal caring.

When Colossians was written, Epaphras was visiting Paul in prison (4:12). He had told Paul about some of the difficulties the new church was going through. He was especially concerned about some false teachers in Colosse who were emphasizing the importance of "the powers and authorities" and "spiritual forces of the world" (2:15; 2:8,20). These teachings were taking away from Christ's highest place and authority. Paul wrote to address these issues.

Summary

Colossians divides into two parts. Chapters 1-2 focus on theology (teaching about God and his work), while chapters 3-4 address practical matters.

Paul begins with greetings and a thanksgiving section (1:1-2; 1:3-14). This was a common way to begin New Testament letters. Then, to make this point clear, Paul quotes and adapts a hymn about Christ's supreme authority (1:15-20). He then makes a practical application (1:21-23).

He next discusses his role as an apostle to the Gentiles (1:24-2:5). Paul urges the Colossians to remain

faithful to Christ Jesus, the one who provides for their spiritual life (2:6-15). The theological section of the letter ends with a warning not to focus too much on rules as a way to achieve spiritual maturity (2:16-23).

The more practical part of the letter (chapters 3-4) begins with a call to turn away from a lifestyle of sin and embrace a new life in Christ (3:1-11). Paul then gives instructions for the Christian community and family life (3:12-17; 3:18-4:1). The letter ends with encouragement to pray (4:2-6) and comments about Paul's fellow workers and other Christians (4:7-18).

Date and Purpose of Writing

Colossians, Ephesians, Philemon, and Philippians are called the Prison Letters. Paul wrote them while in jail for preaching about Jesus Christ (see Colossians 4:18). Ephesians, Colossians, and Philemon are closely related. Paul probably wrote them from the same place at about the same time (either Rome or Ephesus; see Ephesians Book Introduction, "Date and Place of Writing").

These three letters share similar themes and vocabulary. They were also written to people in the same region. Colossae was about 190 kilometers (120 miles) east of Ephesus in the Roman province of Asia. Philemon lived in Colossae.

Paul mentioned some of the same fellow workers in each of the Prison Letters. In his letter to Philemon, he explained why he was sending back Onesimus, Philemon's slave who had run away. Onesimus also traveled with the letter to the Colossians (4:9).

In both Colossians and Ephesians, Paul said that Tychicus would give the churches more details about Paul's situation (Colossians 4:7; Ephesians 6:21). Tychicus was probably the messenger who carried these three letters to their destinations in Asia Minor.

The False Teaching

Paul wrote to the Colossians because false teachers were troubling the church. Colossae was an important trading center on one of the main Roman roads in the region. As a result, people there were exposed to ideas from many religions and philosophies.

Like many false teachings, the "Colossian heresy" was probably a mixture of ideas and practices that were common at the time. We do not know who these teachers were or exactly what they taught. However, we can identify some features of their teaching:

- They seem to have insisted that Christians observe Sabbath and new moon festivals (Colossians 2:16). This suggests some Jewish influence.
- They focused heavily on following rules, especially rules about the body and self-denial (asceticism).
- They placed great importance on spiritual beings, a common feature of many religious movements in that period.

The central problem was clear: their teaching did not present Christ as the source and center of true spiritual life. Any teaching or philosophy that fails to do this is not the good news.

Meaning and Message

In his letter to the Colossians, Paul calls a young Christian church back to the apostles' message of the good news about Christ. To counter false teaching, Paul stresses that Christ is supreme over all creation, both spiritual and physical. Jesus is the one in whom the fullness of God lives. He is also the only true source of spiritual growth. All genuine spiritual life comes from him (Colossians 2:19).

The false teachers based their emphasis on rules on something other than Christ. As a result, those rules could not produce true spiritual growth (Colossians 2:23). Paul argues that adding anything to Christ actually takes away the power he alone provides for living a Christian life.

Christ has reconciled us to the God in whom we now live, so all of our spiritual needs are fulfilled by Christ. We need no one and nothing else for true spiritual fulfillment.

Paul urged the Colossians to avoid focusing too much on ritual practices (Colossians 2:16–23). Instead, all Christians should identify with Christ in his death and resurrection (2:11, 19–20; 3:1–4). They must let the good news about Jesus, as preached by the apostles, shape their thoughts and actions.

Colossians reminds us to keep Christ at the center of our lives and of the church. When we add other things to Christ as the basis of our faith, we distort the true Christian message.